

Time Digital

Not In iTunes With Asia

ASIA IS THE hotbed of new technology, at least when it comes to adopting personal entertainment systems. MP3 players are one of the hottest selling gadgets here, but in a continent riddled with piracy, is it any wonder that buying music online is almost non-existent? *Time* magazine's Bryan Walsh tried to find out why:

All Nick Freer wants is his digital music, and he's even willing to pay for it. When the Hong Kong-based client-services director bought an iPod, it came with software to link with iTunes, Apple Computer's fee-based Internet music store that now dominates 70% of the online-music market. From his computer, Freer can browse every one of iTunes million-plus songs. He just can't buy any of them—consumers can only purchase and download iTunes tracks now in the U.S., the U.K., France and Germany, because the service only takes credit cards issued in those countries. “I find it very annoying,” says Freer, who instead swaps music with friends and uses file-sharing networks.

Commercial online-music sites have hit it big in the US and Europe, thanks to the success of iTunes, which recently sold its 100 millionth song. Even Microsoft is shouldering its way into the business. Last week, the software giant launched its U.S. online-music store, MSN Music. But to the frustration of millions of willing Asians with MP3 players and broadband connections, buying the latest hits online is difficult, because the big U.S. music sites are ignoring the region and local alternatives are few.

An Apple spokesman declined to discuss why iTunes is not offered in Asia, saying they don't talk about future marketing plans in the press. But according to industry experts, the added complexity of licensing music and handling digital rights in unfamiliar territories and fractured markets has dissuaded heavies such as iTunes, RealPlayer and Wal-Mart from catering to Asian users for now. Rampant online piracy in places like Taiwan and South Korea also means that many recording labels in Asia still view the Internet as an enemy, not a sales opportunity. They don't want to license tunes to online sellers, fearing songs downloaded legitimately would soon be widely circulated illegally. One of the main online priorities right now, says Yashudi Ide of Sony Music Entertainment, the Japanese electronic giant's record label, “is to protect copyrights.”

A handful of enterprising entrepreneurs find that attitude anachronistic. They're trying to make space in Asia's \$5.2 billion music market for legal downloads. In 1999, Sudhanshu Saronwala quit his job as the managing director of MTV Asia to co-found the Singapore-based online-music store Soundbuzz. The venture made little progress for four years, but after iTunes proved a commercial success last year, Saronwala is trying again. “The labels have seen that online can be a real, viable distribution channel,” says Saronwala.

To read the entire article, visit <http://snipurl.com/whereisthemusic>



Time Magazine

Jobs Galore, Or Just A Mirage?

HERE'S AN INTERESTING article from *Time* that talks us through the paradox of the job market in the IT sector in India. It's an insightful piece on the crushing unemployment problem despite the trumpeted hiring spree:

For job seekers in India's tech sector, it's the best of times—and the worst. When Venugopal Rao Moram, a 29-year-old software engineer living in Bangalore, began looking for a new job in June this year, it took him just two weeks before he found the work he wanted—a position with Microsoft in the city of Hyderabad. “The moment you put your résumé on the Internet, the offers start coming in,” says Moram, who's been working in the tech sector for six years. “Everyone looking for a job has at least five offers.”

Lalit Kumar, a 22-year-old resident of New Delhi who works part time as a data-entry operator, hasn't found the job market quite as receptive to his talents. Kumar, one of the tens of thousands of young Indians who thronged a giant IT job fair in the city's Pragati Maidan exhibition center on Aug. 23, squats in a corner of the hall at the end of a long

day. He's been trying to hand out résumés all morning, but no recruiter has bothered taking one. “Everyone in Delhi wants to be in IT right now. There are a hundred applicants for every post. It's impossible to get a job unless you have experience,” he says. Pankaj Kamboj, a 22-year-old recent engineering graduate who has come with a half-dozen friends from the neighboring state of Haryana, complains: “We've traveled 200 km for nothing.



There are no software positions here, only call-center jobs.”

India's tech sector is in the grip of an extraordinary paradox. With almost all tech companies on a hiring spree, there's never been more demand for élite employees who have attended the right colleges or have a few years' experience at a prestigious company. Yet for hundreds of thousands of starry-eyed young men and women who are drawn to the IT sector in the hope that it will provide a way out of India's crushing unemployment problem, the promise of a high-paying job is turning out to be a mirage.

India's tech companies are expected to hire 75,000 to 100,000 people this year—a 50% increase compared with last year—because after years of relatively sluggish growth, the sector is roaring again. Revenues for India's IT businesses will grow by a heady 40% this year, according to Vijay Baoney, a technology analyst at Indian brokerage house Enam Securities. The problem for companies is finding enough midlevel executives who can train, groom and oversee the influx of raw recruits. “Experienced hires are not there on the scale that the industry needs them,” says Hema Ravichandar, head of human resources at Infosys, one of the three largest Indian IT companies.

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